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Titus

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Titus

A. Overview and Summary.

1. Titus is one of three so-called “pastoral letters” written to a young pastor named Titus. The other two were written to Timothy. Date of the writing is believed to be between 62-64 AD by Paul from either Corinth or Nicopolis (3:12). Titus had served with Paul on both his first and second missionary journeys and like Timothy, had become a true son in the faith (1:4). Paul mentions Titus in 2 Corinthians where he refers to Titus as “my brother” (2:13) and “my partner and fellow worker” (8:23). Altogether, Titus is referred to by Paul 13 times in the New Testament; 9 times in 2 Corinthians alone.
2. In a similar fashion to 1st and 2nd Timothy, Paul gives encouragement and counsel to a young pastor, who, although well-versed in doctrine, faced opposition from ungodly men within the churches where he ministered. Although not a doctrinal book, Paul affirms election (1:1), saving grace (2:11), Christ’s deity and second coming (2:13), Christ’s substitutionary atonement (2:14), and the regeneration of believers by the Holy Spirit (3:5).
3. The last mention of Titus in the New Testament indicates he was with Paul during Paul’s final Roman imprisonment. From there, he was sent to Dalmatia (2 Timothy 4:10), now called Serbia and Montenegro. He was a Gentile born of a Greek father on the island of Crete. Church tradition has him die of natural causes, but the year is disputed as either 96 AD or 107 AD. A relic, reportedly his skull, is kept at the Church of Saint Titus in Heraklion, Crete.

B. Chapter One.

1. In his opening salutation to Titus, Paul states the purpose of his apostleship: “to build up the faith of God’s elect and their knowledge of the truth that leads to godliness, in the hope of eternal life that God, who cannot lie, promised before time began” (1:1-2). He goes on to say that the reason he left Titus in Crete was to appoint elders in every town (1:5). He enumerates the qualifications of an elder: “one who is blameless, the husband of one wife, having faithful children not accused of wildness or rebellion. For an overseer, as God’s administrator, must be blameless, not arrogant, not hot-tempered, not addicted to wine, not a bully, not greedy for money, but hospitable, loving what is good, sensible, righteous, holy, self-controlled, holding to the faithful message as taught, so that

he will be able both to encourage with sound teaching and to refute those who contradict it” (1:6-9).

2. Although similar to the qualifications listed for an elder in 1 Timothy 3:17, there are minor differences. In Timothy, there is mention that he should: conduct himself in good taste; not be offensive to others; be gentle; not be a new convert, and have a good reputation in the community. In Titus, there is mention that he is God’s administrator, not self-willed, loves good, upright, and holy. Titus does not contain qualifications for deacons. That may be due to the fact that the qualifications given in 1 Timothy are almost identical except for the ability of an elder to teach.
3. He goes on to warn Titus: “For there are also many rebellious people, full of empty talk and deception, especially those from Judaism. It is necessary to silence them; they overthrow whole households by teaching what they shouldn’t to gain money dishonestly” (1:10-11).
4. He closes the chapter with: “To the pure, everything is pure, but to those who are defiled and unbelieving, nothing is pure; in fact, both their mind and conscience are defiled. They profess to know God, but they deny Him by their works. They are detestable, disobedient, and disqualified for any good work” (1:15-16).

C. Chapter Two.

1. Paul admonishes Titus to teach sound Christian principles. He describes the characteristics of older men and women before proceeding to discuss the principles of living for younger men and women, as well as slaves. He makes note of such things as level-headedness, respect, and being sound in faith. And for the women, to be reverent, and to teach the younger women to love their husbands and children. (2:1-5). He tells Titus, “Make yourself an example of good works with integrity and dignity in your teaching. Your message is to be sound beyond reproach, so that the opponent will be ashamed, having nothing bad to say about us” (2:7-8).
2. He concludes the chapter with: “For the grace of God has appeared with salvation for all people, instructing us to deny godlessness and worldly lusts and to live in a sensible, righteous, and godly way in the present age, while we wait for the blessed hope and appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior, Jesus Christ. He gave Himself for us to redeem us from all lawlessness and to cleanse for Himself a people for His own possession, eager to do good works.

Say these things and encourage and rebuke with all authority. Let no one disregard you (2:11-15).

D. Chapter Three.

1. Paul gives instructions about Titus's teaching as to how his church should conduct themselves towards those outside of the church: "Remind them to be submissive to rulers and authorities, to obey, to be ready for every good work, to slander no one, to avoid fighting, and to be kind, always showing gentleness to all people. For we too were once foolish, disobedient, deceived, enslaved by various passions and pleasures, living in malice and envy, hateful, detesting one another" (3:1-3).
2. He presents the pure gospel: " But when the kindness of God our Savior, and his love toward man, appeared, not by works done in righteousness, which we did ourselves, but according to his mercy he saved us, through the washing of regeneration and renewing of the Holy Spirit, which he poured out upon us richly, through Jesus Christ our Savior; that, being justified by his grace, we might be made heirs according to the hope of eternal life. Faithful is the saying, and concerning these things I desire that thou affirm confidently, to the end that they who have believed God may be careful to maintain good works. These things are good and profitable unto men" (3:4-8).
3. He then gives a warning: "shun foolish questionings, and genealogies, and strife, and fighting about the law; for they are unprofitable and vain. A factious man after a first and second admonition refuse; knowing that such a one is perverted, and sinful, being self-condemned" (3:9-11).
4. He closes the book with instructions about other co-workers and a final blessing: All that are with me salute thee. Salute them that love us in faith. Grace be with you all" (3:15).

E. Discussion Questions, Application and Passing it on.

1. Do you profess to know God but deny Him by your works? (1:16). This is a serious matter and may be an indication of your true salvation.
2. If you are a church leader, do you possess the attributes listed by Paul. There are many church leaders who have secret sins that they are not dealing with. Do you have any?
3. When would it not be appropriate to submit to rulers and authorities? (3:1).

This New Testament survey was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org)

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